

Chapter 23 - Bastard

Chu Qingqiu suddenly stopped in her tracks. Her gaze first fell on the flowers - those chrysanthemums were indeed fresh, each petal like white jade with sparkling dewdrops scattered on them, blooming clean and passionately.

The young girl's face was even more passionate. The sunlight dispelled the evil aura, sprinkling gold at the bottom of her eyes and dyeing her temples with clear, transparent gold.

Anyone would be mesmerized by looking at her for just a moment longer.

Chu Qingqiu immediately averted her gaze, only looking at the flowers, deliberately ignoring the surging emotions in her heart, not daring to look again.

The bustling crowd walked past them both. Ning Fuyi was puzzled why Chu Qingqiu had no reaction and was about to speak when she heard a soft voice: "These flowers, where did you get them?"

"What do you mean 'get'? I bought them." Ning Fuyi waved the bouquet in her hand and gestured toward the distance with her chin. "Look, that flower shop."

Chu Qingqiu turned to look, her lips unconsciously tightening.

"Do you usually buy flowers from funeral shops¹ to give to people?" Chu Qingqiu seemed to have carefully chosen her words for a long time before slowly speaking.

Funeral shop? Ning Fuyi didn't believe it at first, squinting to look. When she clearly saw the sign outside the shop, her heart skipped a beat and suddenly the flowers in her hand felt as heavy as a thousand pounds.

It was over, it was over. In her haste earlier, she hadn't looked clearly at the shop name. This shop also didn't look as gloomy as other funeral shops, so she had actually bought the wrong thing.

"They're all flowers. What difference does it make where they're bought from?" Ning Fuyi didn't care about etiquette to begin with. With one sentence, she convinced herself and confidently pushed the flowers toward Chu Qingqiu again. "Don't you think these flowers are quite pleasing to the eye?"

Indeed pleasing, Chu Qingqiu closed her eyes, her wrist moved, then seemed to remember something: "Why give them to me?"

"Wenzhu saw you were in a bad mood and asked me to comfort you." Ning Fuyi never took credit, telling the truth honestly.

Like a basin of cold water being poured down, Chu Qingqiu's eyebrows furrowed almost imperceptibly. She suddenly turned to one side, her tone immediately becoming much colder:

"This venerable was merely tired. Why do you presume to know better?"

Ning Fuyi had finally swallowed her pride to humor her, not knowing why she suddenly became cold again. She felt like her warm face had met a cold backside, and a surge of evil fire rose in her heart.

"I should have known that someone as high and mighty as the Divine Venerable wouldn't need comfort from the likes of us." She said in a low voice. "Since the Divine Venerable doesn't need it, then it's indeed this disciple making trouble from nothing, offending the Divine Venerable's eyes."

"Divine Venerable, take your time. This disciple takes her leave." As she spoke, she looked around left and right. Not seeing anywhere to throw trash, she simply walked around Chu Qingqiu and ran back to that shop, throwing the bouquet in front of the shopkeeper. "Shopkeeper, I don't want these flowers anymore. Here, take them back!"

The shopkeeper was startled. Seeing it was Ning Fuyi, he touched his head in difficulty:

"Distinguished guest, this... our small shop runs a small business. Once sold, no returns or exchanges."

"I don't want the money back. You can keep it." Ning Fuyi said irritably, then turned and strode off in the opposite direction.

On the other side, watching Ning Fuyi's uncaring retreating figure, Chu Qingqiu's heart, already full of anger, had another log thrown on the fire. She clenched her delicate hands and stood in place with her eyes closed, holding her breath.

Good for her, that Ning Fuyi was really something, a bastard in both past and present lives. You couldn't reason with her or scold her.

"Bastard." Chu Qingqiu cursed in a low voice, then angrily swept her sleeves and strode away.

"Distinguished guest, take care." The shopkeeper called out to Ning Fuyi's retreating figure, then smiled broadly as he took out the water jade and kissed it. He picked up the bouquet, planning to put it back in its original place with a happy mood.

However, just as he reached out his hand, he heard someone knocking on the door frame. He hurriedly turned around and was stunned by the woman's appearance.

What major funeral was happening in Furong Town today? How were the people coming one after another all of such outstanding temperament? The shopkeeper muttered in his heart, but his face immediately filled with smiles: "What would you like, distinguished guest? Do you like this wreath or that wreath? There are also coffins inside, made of Green Dragon Wood² - so beautiful!"

"I don't want coffins. I want that bouquet." The woman said in a low voice, while speaking, she took out several pieces of broken jade from her sleeve and placed them on the counter.

"Distinguished guest, this..." The shopkeeper pointed at those pieces of broken jade hesitantly.

"She's careless and brainless. Do you think everyone else is the same?" The woman glared at him, and the shopkeeper immediately broke out in a cold sweat, not daring to say more. He respectfully handed over the bouquet in his hands.

The woman took the flowers and disappeared in the blink of an eye.

The shopkeeper immediately breathed a sigh of relief, sat down heavily, and began wiping his forehead with a handkerchief.

After Elder Yuanming helped treat the rescued Spirit Clan members, he handed over the matter of Spirit Clan trafficking to the Tianji Sword Sect³, the leader of the six sects. Early the next morning, he set off with Ning Fuyi and her group toward the Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate.

Ning Fuyi slept the entire journey, unaware that her exploits from these past two days had already spread throughout the Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, becoming a topic of conversation among the disciples for many days. The disciples of Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate had always thought of her as a useless young sect leader, looking down on her with disdain. Therefore, her escape from Ghost Eye and accompanying Chu Qingqiu to bring down Ruyan Tower greatly exceeded everyone's expectations.

Although the vast majority knew this was Divine Venerable Chu Ling's accomplishment, many disciples had never encountered such major events in their hundred years of cultivation, so they still envied Ning Fuyi greatly. This envy, when heard by some who harbored resentment toward her, made them furious.

For example, Li Zhao'an. She dragged her recently reattached leg that wasn't working very well yet. Upon hearing that Ning Fuyi had returned alive, she was so angry that she locked herself in her room for several consecutive days without cultivating.

As soon as Ning Fuyi stepped into the sect, she felt an atmosphere different from usual. Fellow disciples from various courtyards who used to ignore her now all greeted her when they saw her. Many people asked her about the details of this journey, which made Ning Fuyi feel somewhat flattered. For several consecutive days, her mood was quite good as she resumed her normal life.

Seeing the Zhaoyao Conference⁴ approaching ever closer, disciples from all courtyards were emerging under stars and returning under moonlight, gritting their teeth in cultivation, hoping to be selected by the four great elders to participate in the Zhaoyao Conference. Although Ning Fuyi held no hope for the Zhaoyao Conference, given this diligent atmosphere, she rarely joined the morning cultivation.

But the bigger reason was that she wanted to figure out the origin of that power within her body. However, she had inquired with many teaching elders, questioned Elder Xueyuan who managed all the books, and even asked the Chief Elder who was in seclusion all day, but got no answers.

That Chief Elder, old as a candle in the wind and unable to move, felt her pulse for a long time, made a "pah" sound, then fell asleep with his mouth open. This made Ning Fuyi suspect whether her cultivation was so low that her brain had problems, making her hallucinate that she had repelled the demonic beast.

She had also thought of asking Chu Qingqiu, but after hesitating outside Jingshan Palace for half a day, she still turned around angrily.

Since that day, she still harbored resentment and didn't want to touch that killing god's bad luck.

Coming and going like this, time passed through five days and nights. This afternoon, Ning Fuyi was sitting in the noisy dining hall, listening to inquiries from fellow disciples around her while stuffing her stomach with big bites, trying to finish eating quickly and leave this wretched place early.

"Young Sect Leader, just tell us - how did Divine Venerable Chu Ling bring you out of Ghost Eye that day?" The female disciple with the sky-high pigtails sat across from Ning Fuyi and asked.

"Only someone as amazing as the Divine Venerable could be so formidable, entering and exiting Ghost Eye twice." The bald male disciple said with a slightly red face. He squeezed next to Ning Fuyi and whispered: "Young Sect Leader, how about you tell us?"

"Want to know? Go ask Chu Qingqiu. Why ask me?" Ning Fuyi said irritably, so annoyed she wanted to pull off her ears. These questions had brought some joy of being noticed for the first few days, but having people chase after her asking for five consecutive days was really deadly.

The female disciple shivered: "I wouldn't dare. Just being looked at by her once makes me feel like I've fallen into an ice cellar. Who would dare approach someone as aloof as Divine Venerable Chu Ling?"

"She's a Divine Venerable - how could she let you approach?" The male disciple defended her.

"She's not the only one who's reached the Great Vehicle Realm⁵. Why isn't anyone else this terrifying? That Heavenly Auspicious Emperor from Penglai Realm, and our former sect leader - which one wasn't amiable and approachable?" The female disciple muttered.

"You're right." Ning Fuyi nodded in agreement.

"That doesn't make sense..." The male disciple slapped the table. Just as they were about to argue, Ning Fuyi quickly grabbed her rice bowl, said she was done eating, turned to put down her bowl and chopsticks, and slipped away.

When she reached the cool shade of trees outside, she finally breathed a sigh of relief, rubbing her ears as she walked toward Pearl Light Pavilion, thinking of taking a short rest.

Unexpectedly, after just two steps, she heard the clip-clop of footsteps. She turned around to see Liu Wenzhu running toward her under the scorching noon sun, her face covered in sweat.

"Yiyi, quick! Something terrible has happened!" She stopped in front of Ning Fuyi like wind. Without waiting for Ning Fuyi to speak, she dragged her up and ran back like wind again, nearly pulling Ning Fuyi's arm from its socket.

"Slow down! What happened?" Ning Fuyi helplessly lengthened her stride to keep up with her pace, asking breathlessly.

"It's Li Zhao'an. She somehow heard about us bringing back a Spirit Clan member and is leading people to cause trouble at Yinglai Pavilion⁶!" Liu Wenzhu said angrily while pulling Ning Fuyi around a corner. Ning Fuyi's feet immediately left the ground, then she was pulled back mid-air, staggering to resume running.

That Man'er had been unconscious since fainting at Ruyan Tower. Although Ning Fuyi wanted to ask about her identity, she was helpless and could only settle her in Yinglai Pavilion, the guest quarters of Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, planning to decide what to do when she woke up.

This Li Zhao'an really had a keen nose, able to follow scents to find trouble with her in everything. Ning Fuyi cursed inwardly but also quickened her pace. Fortunately, the dining hall wasn't far from Yinglai Pavilion. Soon Ning Fuyi ran into the courtyard and saw a crowd gathered in a circle, with Li Zhao'an in the center, her head full of silk flowers, speaking arrogantly.

Across from her stood a young girl, her body frail as a willow branch, tearfully explaining something. The moment Ning Fuyi stepped across the threshold, she suddenly turned around, her gaze piercing through the bustling crowd to meet Ning Fuyi's eyes from afar.

Ning Fuyi immediately stopped, a strange feeling spreading through her heart.

That gaze was really, really too familiar.

Du Baishuang.

Du Baishuang came to her much, much later, so long after those events that Ning Fuyi had forgotten she was once human. She was given to her as a gift from the Demon Clan alliance when she was already the infamous Heaven-Punishing God Demon.

At that time, Ning Fuyi had already become the notorious Heaven-Punishing God Demon. She occupied a corner of the Demon Cave and established herself as king, loving neither fine food and wine nor gold, silver, and treasures. Other demon clans wanting to curry favor with her thought and thought, then found the number one beauty of the six realms and packaged her as a gift to send over.

When Ning Fuyi learned they had sent her a person, she originally wanted to wave her hand and throw the person out of the Demon Cave. However, when the gift bag was opened and she saw that face, her hand could no longer wave down.

It wasn't because Du Baishuang was particularly beautiful. Although she was indeed nationally beautiful with a willow waist and flower-like grace, truly deserving the title of the number one beauty of the six realms, what truly caught Ning Fuyi's attention was that she looked seventy percent like Chu Qingqiu.

A young, similar face, yet obedient and well-behaved, clever and quick-witted, knowing how to please people. Ning Fuyi didn't know what evil possessed her, but she kept her.

In the days that followed, she always liked to call her to come before her. She didn't do anything, just stared at that face. Du Baishuang was also really well-behaved, gentle and accommodating in every way, using every method to please her.

Ning Fuyi actually knew her purpose and knew whose person she was, but she didn't expose it. She just enjoyed the days of looking at that face, until one day Du Baishuang drew her sword and stabbed at her while she was sleeping. Only then did Ning Fuyi end this strange psychology and take her life with a raised hand.

Did she like her? No. But when that absolutely beautiful face lost its color, she actually shed a tear.

Only because in this world, there was truly no one left to accompany her.

Ning Fuyi blinked, stopping this memory.

She exhaled and was about to step forward when she saw the young girl suddenly fall as if struck, then struggle to get up under Li Zhao'an's shocked gaze, rush out of the crowd, and tightly embrace Ning Fuyi's waist in full view of everyone.

"Sister, save me." Her small body trembled as she sobbed.

Author's Notes:

Chu Qingqiu: Oh my, here comes the love rival.

Footnotes:

1. **Funeral shops (凶肆)** - Traditional Chinese shops that sell funeral-related items, where buying flowers for the living is considered inauspicious
 2. **Green Dragon Wood (青龙木)** - A mythical wood type often used in cultivation novels for making high-quality items
 3. **Tianji Sword Sect (天玑剑宗)** - One of the six great sects, described as their leader
 4. **Zhaoyao Conference (招摇大会)** - A major cultivation conference/competition
 5. **Great Vehicle Realm (大乘)** - One of the higher cultivation realms
 6. **Yinglai Pavilion (迎来阁)** - The guest quarters of Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate
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Author's Notes: This chapter reveals the complex backstory between Ning Fuyi and Du Baishuang (Man'ei), showing how their paths crossed in Ning Fuyi's previous life as the Heaven-Punishing God Demon. The emotional revelation adds depth to Ning Fuyi's character while setting up potential complications with this "love rival" appearing just as her relationship with Chu Qingqiu is developing.